

Here's a real-life story that brings critical illness insurance to life

Three years ago, life was a careful balancing act. A single parent. Two kids. One income. Every dollar had a job.

The insurance advisor sat across the kitchen table and walked through a critical illness policy — coverage designed to pay a tax-free lump sum upon diagnosis of one of the four core conditions most base CI policies cover: **cancer, heart attack, stroke, and life-threatening coronary artery bypass surgery.**

The numbers are sobering. For someone in their forties, roughly **1 in 2 Canadians will be diagnosed with cancer in their lifetime** — and survival rates have climbed dramatically, with many cancers now carrying **5-year survival rates above 60–80%**. Heart attack and stroke together affect tens of thousands of Canadians in their forties annually, with survival increasingly common thanks to advances in emergency care.

Surviving was no longer the question. *Affording to survive* — that was the real risk.

But that night, after the kids were in bed, the budget spreadsheet told a different story. Groceries. Rent. Childcare. Car insurance. Life insurance. The CI premium felt like one obligation too many. *Can we really afford this?*

The decision was made to find a way. The cable package went. The weekly takeout became monthly. Sixty-two dollars a month freed up. The policy was signed.

Life moved on. Hockey practices. School projects. Promotions. Small wins.

Then, 6 months ago, a lump. A referral. A diagnosis. **Breast cancer. Advanced stage. Treatable.**

The medical team was extraordinary. But treatment meant time away from work, and time away from work creates a financial cliff that no amount of sick leave and group benefit plans can fully cushion.

Six weeks after the claim submission, the CI claim was approved.

The lump sum arrived — **tax-free** — and it was like someone had removed a boot from the chest. The mortgage was covered. The kids' routines stayed intact. There was even enough to bring in help during recovery.

The policy also came with a **return-of-premium** feature — meaning had a claim never been made, every dollar paid in could have been returned.

No one plans to get sick. But someone, three years ago, at a kitchen table, chose to plan *for* it.

That decision helped keep someone's world together.